Your Next Paycheck Checklist

Fill this in after your paycheck clears, before you spend anything optional. Five steps, about ten minutes. Use your real take-home pay, not your salary.

1 Confirm your starting cash

Take-home pay that cleared $ _____ + Unassigned money left over $ _____

= **Starting cash** $ _____

Leave out pending charges and money you've already set aside. Don't count the deposit twice.

2 Cover your bills first

Bills due before your next payday $ _____ +

Set aside for bigger bills coming later $ _____

A bill due on your next payday may still need money from *this* paycheck, in case the deposit lands late.

3 Plan the rest of your commitments

Future costs (car, gifts, renewals) $ _____ Groceries and transport $ _____

Other essentials $ _____ Savings $ _____

Cushion to keep in checking $ _____

4 See your spending room

Starting cash − everything in steps 2 and 3 = **Spending room** $ _____

If it's negative, that's a shortfall. Revisit steps 2 and 3 before any optional spending. A plan can't create money that isn't there, but it shows you the gap early.

5 Set your next check-in

Next payday _____ Mid-period check (halfway to payday) _____

At the check-in, compare what you actually spent and moved. Keep every set-aside dollar counted once.

Hypothetical example: $2,400 take-home + $100 left over = **$2,500** starting cash. Bills and set-asides $1,020 + future costs $120 + groceries and transport $260 + other essentials $40 + savings $100 + cushion $100 = $1,640. Spending room: **$860** for the next 14 days.

Want the math done for you? The Pay In Order workbook (Google Sheets and Excel) does every step above automatically, and adds bill set-asides, a future-costs planner, a spending log and a dashboard. See it at **payinorder.com**.

General budgeting education, not financial advice. Example numbers are hypothetical. No bank connection required. © Pay In Order · payinorder.com